



Union battery at Cold Harbor

During the battle of June 1, these Union Sixth Corps gunners fought so close to the Confederate line that they were nicknamed "Battery Insult."

Battle resumes

At 4:30 a.m. on June 3, the signal gun fired and some 25,000 Union soldiers emerged from their works and crossed the muddy fields. Few of them had time to study the Rebel breastworks. Across the nearly 7-mile (11-km) line, a mighty crash of Confederate cannon and rifle fire erupted that lit up the dawn sky and rattled the windows in Richmond.

Volley after murderous volley tore through the blue-clad ranks. Entire lines were cut down, and whole regiments disintegrated. In the midst of the pandemonium, General Francis Barlow's brigade briefly took a section of the Confederate earthworks, amidst a scene of sheer slaughter. In some places only minutes passed before survivors were pinned down by rifle fire as their officers urged them forward in vain.